

WILBUR AND ORVILLE WRIGHT

WILBUR (1867–1912) AND ORVILLE (1871–1948) were the third and fifth sons of Milton Wright, a bishop in the evangelical Church of the United Brethren in Christ, and his wife Susan. Wilbur would have attended college but for a freak sports accident at the age of 18 that undermined his health for several years. In any event, neither brother had a college education and both stayed at home, running several businesses before moving into the bicycle business in 1892. Originally setting up just to rent bicycles, they soon expanded into building their own, which they sold for a remarkably low price (\$18 compared to the \$160 that Orville paid for his first bicycle in 1892). Inspired by the death of Otto Lilienthal in 1896, the Wright brothers started to finance their

“From the time we were little children, my brother Orville and myself lived together, played together, worked together, and... thought together.”

WILBUR WRIGHT

aeronautical experiments from 1899 onward with the profits from the bicycle business. They calculated that it cost them \$1,000 to crack the problem of powered flight. Their experiences dealing with something as inherently unstable as a bicycle, and the insights it gave them into combining lightness with strength to achieve balance and control, gave them a novel approach to the problem of creating a workable heavier-than-air flying machine.

Inventive and self-reliant, the brothers not only had the practical skills to make their own tools and engines, they were also voracious readers with the intellect to work out complex theoretical problems. Their ingenuity and persistence as methodical experimenters was matched by their physical bravery as test pilots. Yet they were cautious individuals – Wilbur, in particular, flew only when absolutely necessary for experimental or demonstration purposes.

Neither brother had any taste for luxurious living. They did not smoke or drink, and they were rarely seen with any women other than their sister. When Wilbur carried out his demonstration flights



WRIGHT CYCLE SHOP

The bicycle became fashionable in the 1890s, and the Wright brothers combined their entrepreneurial and engineering skills when they opened up their own “Wright Cycle Co.” in Dayton, Ohio, in 1892.

in France in 1908, he was cheered by crowds and courted by princes and businessmen, but he cooked his own meals and slept in a hangar with his flying machine.

The brothers combined supreme self-confidence with a deep mistrust of everyone outside their family circle. They were stubborn, hard-headed businessmen, relentless in the legal pursuit of those they thought had wronged them. Essentially private people, they coped very well with the immense fame they earned. Wilbur tragically died of typhoid fever in 1912; Orville lived on into the jet age, dying in 1948.



IN THE WORKSHOP

Orville (right) is shown with a worker at the Wright Cycle Company workshop in 1897. The availability of raw materials and machinery in their well-equipped shop helped the Wright brothers with their investigations into the flying problem.



THE TOAST OF EUROPE

Wilbur (left) and Orville are pictured during their 1909 European tour, when they were feted by kings, politicians, and generals in France, Italy, and England.

THE COUPE DE MICHELIN TROPHY

Wilbur Wright won this trophy for the world-record-breaking distance and duration flight he made in December 1908, in France. He flew for more than two hours and covered over 62 miles (100km).

